Qualia as a Non-Operational Posit: A Structural Reconstruction

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Abstract

The concept of qualia is commonly invoked to account for the subjective character of experience and to motivate the explanatory gap. This paper argues that qualia do not function as a justified explanatory posit. The analysis introduces three minimal criteria for explanatory concepts: causal role, distinguishable difference, and conditions of application. It then shows that qualia satisfy none of them.

The central claim is that qualia arise from an unjustified transition from a difference in epistemic access (first-person versus third-person) to a difference in ontology. On this view, the explanatory gap is not discovered but generated by the introduction of an additional posit. The argument does not deny experience, but rejects the need to treat it as an additional explanatory entity. Once the underlying conceptual transition is removed, no explanatory content is lost.

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1 Introduction

The concept of qualia occupies a central place in contemporary discussions of consciousness. It is typically introduced to capture the subjective character of experience, often described as what it is like to undergo a particular mental state (Nagel, 1974; Chalmers, 1996). This aspect is commonly treated as resistant to physical or functional explanation and is therefore taken to motivate the introduction of an additional explanatory layer, often framed in terms of the explanatory gap (Levine, 1983).

In what follows, by "qualia" I mean non-functional, non-relational, intrinsically subjective properties posited as explanatory additions to physical or functional descriptions of experience.

This definition is not intended to cover all uses of the term, but to isolate the role qualia play in arguments that appeal to an explanatory remainder beyond structural accounts.

A standard formulation of the problem proceeds as follows. Even if a complete description of a system is given in physical or functional terms, it is claimed that something remains unaccounted for, namely the subjective aspect of experience. This remainder is then identified with qualia, and the task becomes to explain how such subjective properties relate to physical processes.

The present paper does not attempt to provide such an explanation. Instead, it addresses a prior question. Before asking how qualia can be explained, it is necessary to determine whether the concept itself introduces any element that can function within an explanatory framework. In other words, the issue is not how to explain qualia, but whether the concept plays any legitimate explanatory role.

To address this question, the paper introduces a minimal diagnostic framework. An explanatory concept must satisfy at least one of the following conditions: it must specify a causal role, produce a distinguishable difference, or define conditions under which it applies or fails. These criteria are not intended to privilege any particular ontology, but to distinguish explanatory posits from concepts that merely redescribe what is already given.

The central claim of this paper is that the concept of qualia does not meet these minimal conditions. It does not specify a causal role, does not produce a distinguishable difference, and does not define conditions of application. As a result, the appeal to qualia does not extend explanatory structure, but reflects a shift in how experience is described.

More specifically, the analysis argues that the notion of qualia arises from a transition in reasoning that is not independently justified. A difference in access between first-person and third-person descriptions is treated as a difference in ontology. This move introduces a distinction between the mental and the physical, and only then raises the question of how the two are related. On this view, the explanatory gap is not discovered but generated by this transition.

This position is best understood as a structural diagnosis of the problem, rather than a defense of a particular ontology. It is also compatible with strategies that locate the apparent gap at the level of concepts rather than properties, although the present argument is concerned with the status of qualia as explanatory posits rather than with phenomenal concepts alone. It is related to deflationary and illusionist approaches (Dennett, 1991; Frankish, 2016), but differs in focusing on the conditions under which explanatory concepts are introduced, rather than on the status of experience itself.

The aim of the paper is to make this structure explicit. Section 2 examines the conceptual basis of the distinction between first-person and third-person descriptions and identifies the point at which it is converted into an ontological claim. Sections 3 to 6 develop a set of minimal constraints on explanatory concepts and apply them to the case of qualia. Section 7 reconstructs the so-called hard problem of consciousness in light of this analysis. The final sections consider the implications of removing the concept of qualia from the explanatory framework.

The overall conclusion is not that experience is eliminated or denied, but that the concept of qualia does not function as a justified explanatory posit. Once the underlying conceptual transition is removed, no explanatory content is lost, and the problem no longer retains its original form.

2 The Ontologization of First-Person Structure

The distinction between first-person and third-person descriptions plays a central role in discussions of consciousness. First-person descriptions refer to the way a system is accessed from within, while third-person descriptions refer to publicly observable or functionally characterizable aspects of the same system. This distinction is uncontroversial at the level of description. Different modes of access to a system can yield different kinds of information about it (Nagel, 1974).

The difficulty arises when this descriptive distinction is treated as an ontological one. In many arguments, the fact that experience has a first-person character is taken to imply that it belongs to a different category of being than what is captured by third-person accounts (Chalmers, 1996). This move is often implicit. The difference in perspective is introduced at the descriptive level, but subsequently reinterpreted as a difference in what exists.

This transition requires justification. It introduces an additional explanatory element that is not contained in the initial description. Without such justification, the move remains a shift in interpretation rather than a consequence of the premises.

Formally, the structure of this transition can be expressed as follows. Let A_1 denote first-person access and A_3 denote third-person access. It is unproblematic to state that

$$A_1 \neq A_3,$$

in the sense that the two modes of access are not equivalent. However, this does not entail that there exists an additional ontological element E such that

$$E \notin P,$$

where P denotes the physical or functional description of the system. The inference from a difference in access to the existence of an additional entity is not justified by the initial premise. What is missing is an independent criterion that would license the transition from descriptive asymmetry to ontological duplication.

This step is nonetheless frequently taken. The subjective character of experience is treated as evidence for an element that cannot be captured within physical or functional descriptions. Once this element is introduced, the distinction between the mental and the physical is established, and the problem becomes one of explaining the relation between the two. The so-called explanatory gap is then formulated as the difficulty of accounting for this relation (Levine, 1983).

The present analysis suggests that this structure is inverted. The gap does not precede the distinction; it follows from it. The introduction of a separate ontological category creates the very problem it is supposed to solve. Without this step, there is no independent reason to posit an additional explanatory element beyond the structure of the system itself.

This can be seen more clearly by considering the role of the terms involved. The notion of the mental is typically defined in contrast to the physical. That is, it is characterized as that which is not captured by physical description. This means that the distinction between mental and physical presupposes a shared framework within which both terms are meaningful. The two are not independent categories, but are defined relationally.

As a result, the appeal to a dual ontology does not introduce a new explanatory structure, but reorganizes the existing one. It replaces a single descriptive framework with two interdefined domains, without specifying what is gained by this duplication. Unless the distinction can be shown to correspond to a difference in causal role, observable consequence, or testable condition, it remains at the level of description.

The conclusion of this section is that the move from first-person structure to ontological dualism is not established by argument. It is a transition in the interpretation of descriptive differences. This transition must be made explicit and evaluated before it can serve as the basis for further claims about the nature of consciousness.

3 Minimal Conditions for Explanatory Concepts

In order to assess whether the concept of qualia contributes to explanation, it is necessary to specify minimal conditions under which a concept can function within an explanatory framework. These conditions are not tied to any particular ontology. They define only what is required for a concept to extend, rather than merely restate, an account of a system.

Three conditions will be used in the present analysis. These conditions are intended to be minimal and domain-appropriate. The point is not that every explanation in every domain must satisfy these exact criteria, but that any additional posit introduced into a theory of consciousness must do some identifiable explanatory work. They do not privilege any specific form of explanation, but aim to distinguish explanatory posits from concepts that do no non-trivial work within an explanatory structure.

First, an explanatory concept must introduce a causal role. That is, it must participate in the processes that generate observable states, behavior, or reports. If a concept is invoked to account for a phenomenon, it must be possible to specify how it contributes to the production of that phenomenon.

Second, an explanatory concept must produce a distinguishable difference. The introduction of the concept should make it possible to differentiate between at least two states of a system. If the presence or absence of the proposed element does not alter any observable, functional, or inferential outcome, then it does not add explanatory content.

Third, an explanatory concept must allow for conditions of application and failure. It must be possible to specify when the concept applies, and under what conditions it would not apply. Without such conditions, the concept cannot be evaluated, and therefore cannot function within a framework of explanation.

These conditions can be summarized as follows. Let C be a proposed explanatory concept. Then C contributes to explanation only if at least one of the following holds:

- C enters into the causal structure of the system,
- C produces a difference between possible states or outcomes,
- C defines conditions under which it can succeed or fail.

If none of these conditions are satisfied, then C does not extend explanatory structure.

Instead, it operates as a redescriptive element, rephrasing existing information without altering the underlying model.

These criteria are minimal in the sense that they do not require reduction to any specific domain, nor do they presuppose a particular theory of mind or matter. They are intended to capture a general constraint on explanation: that a concept must either contribute to the generation of a phenomenon, differentiate between possible states, or define the conditions under which it applies.

The remainder of the paper applies these conditions to the concept of qualia. The aim is not to deny the existence of experience, but to determine whether the introduction of qualia adds any explanatory element beyond what is already captured by the structure of the system. In this sense, the criteria are not intended as a theory of explanation, but as minimal constraints on the use of explanatory posits.

4 The Causal Dilemma

The first test for the concept of qualia concerns its role within the causal structure of a system. The motivation for introducing qualia is typically that existing physical or functional descriptions are claimed to leave something unexplained (Levine, 1983; Chalmers, 1996). However, in order for qualia to address this gap, they must enter into the processes that generate the phenomena in question.

Two possibilities arise.

First, qualia may be taken to be causally efficacious. In this case, they contribute to the production of behavior, reports, or internal state transitions. For example, if a subject reports that they are in pain, and this report is taken to depend on the presence of a pain quale, then the quale must play a role in the causal chain leading to that report. This implies that qualia are functionally integrated into the system. Under these conditions, they are no longer independent of the physical or informational processes that constitute the system, but form part of the same explanatory structure.

Second, qualia may be taken to be causally inert. On this view, qualia accompany physical processes but do not influence them (Jackson, 1982; Chalmers, 1996). The production of behavior and reports is then fully accounted for by physical or functional mechanisms, while qualia remain epiphenomenal. In this case, a structural difficulty arises. If qualia do not contribute to the production of reports about experience, then such reports cannot be grounded in qualia themselves. The link between the concept and the phenomena it is supposed to explain is thereby severed.

This yields a dilemma. If qualia are causally efficacious, they are integrated into the same causal framework as the processes they are meant to supplement. If they are causally inert, then there is no basis for attributing them in explanatory terms. In neither case do qualia introduce an additional explanatory layer.

It is important to note that this is not an argument from ignorance. The claim is not that qualia are false because their mechanism is unknown. Rather, the claim is that the concept fails to specify any role within the structure it is meant to explain. Without such a role, the concept

does not extend the explanatory framework, regardless of whether the underlying phenomena are fully understood.

The force of this argument lies in its neutrality. It does not depend on the truth of physicalism or any competing ontology. It follows directly from minimal conditions on explanation. If a concept is introduced to account for a phenomenon, it must either participate in the processes that produce that phenomenon or alter the structure of its explanation. If it does neither, then it does not resolve the problem it was introduced to address.

The causal dilemma therefore does not eliminate experience or deny its significance. It shows that the introduction of qualia does not contribute to its explanation. The apparent depth of the problem arises from the way the concept is positioned, not from the structure of the system itself.

5 Underdetermination and the Role of Physical Reference

The second test concerns whether the concept of qualia introduces a distinguishable difference within the structure of explanation. This issue is often framed through the idea that a system could be physically or functionally identical to a conscious subject while lacking subjective experience (Chalmers, 1996). The conclusion drawn from this is that the subjective aspect must constitute an additional layer beyond physical description.

However, this argument relies on a specific assumption about how the comparison is defined. The distinction between a system with qualia and one without them is formulated against a shared background of physical or functional equivalence. That is, both cases are assumed to be identical with respect to all observable and functional properties. The difference is then located in an additional, non-observable element.

This means that the argument does not introduce an independent alternative to physical description. This dependence is structural: the distinction is only intelligible relative to a fixed physical or functional baseline, and does not define an independent explanatory domain. It operates within that framework. The notion of a "difference beyond the physical" is only meaningful because the physical structure is already fixed as the reference point. In this sense, physical or functional description is not being imposed as an external assumption. It is built into the formulation of the problem itself.

Given this setup, two possibilities arise.

First, the system with qualia and the system without qualia are indistinguishable in all observable and functional respects. In that case, the introduction of qualia does not alter any explanatory or predictive outcome. The distinction does not correspond to any difference within the structure of the system.

Second, a difference between the two systems is asserted. In that case, the difference must be identifiable in terms of behavior, internal processes, or other observable features. If such a difference can be specified, then the purportedly non-physical element becomes part of the explanatory structure used to describe the system.

This leads to a simple constraint. A difference that produces no difference in the structure of explanation does not function as an explanatory distinction. Conversely, a difference that

does affect the structure of explanation is no longer independent of the framework in which it is described.

The appeal to qualia therefore does not resolve underdetermination, but depends on it. The argument presupposes a fixed physical or functional baseline and then introduces a distinction that either fails to register within that baseline or collapses into it. In neither case does it establish a separate explanatory layer.

This result is not a defense of physicalism as a substantive ontological claim. Rather, it follows from the structure of the argument itself. The reference to physical or functional description is already present in the way the problem is formulated. The analysis only makes explicit the consequences of that reference.

The conclusion is that the concept of qualia does not introduce a distinguishable explanatory difference. It relies on a framework that it does not replace, and adds a distinction that cannot be independently specified within it.

6 Epistemic Failure and the Structure of Reports

The final test concerns the relation between qualia and epistemic access. The concept of qualia is typically supported by first-person reports, such as statements of the form "I experience X." These reports are taken to provide direct evidence for the existence of subjective properties (Nagel, 1974; Chalmers, 1996).

In order for such reports to justify the existence of qualia, a structural condition must be satisfied. The reported content must be causally dependent on the entity it is supposed to establish. This follows from a minimal requirement on epistemic justification: a report can only ground a claim if the factor cited contributes to its production. Otherwise the report may correlate with the alleged factor, but cannot justify it.

Let Q denote qualia and R denote reports about experience. Justification requires:

$$Q \to R$$

where the arrow denotes causal or generative dependence.

Two possibilities arise.

First, qualia may be causally efficacious. In this case:

$$Q \to R$$

That is, the presence of qualia contributes to the production of reports. However, under this condition, qualia are integrated into the causal structure of the system. They become part of the same explanatory framework that accounts for behavior and reporting processes (Dennett, 1991; Frankish, 2016). The distinction between qualia and physical or functional processes is no longer maintained.

Second, qualia may be taken to be causally inert. This position is characteristic of epiphenomenal views, according to which qualia accompany physical processes but do not influence them (Jackson, 1982; Chalmers, 1996). In this case:

$$Q \nrightarrow R$$

Reports about experience are generated independently of qualia, for example by underlying physical or functional mechanisms:

$$R = f(P)$$

where P denotes the physical or functional state of the system.

Under these conditions, reports do not depend on qualia. Therefore, they cannot serve as evidence for their existence. The epistemic link between Q and R is absent.

This yields a constraint:

$$(Q \rightarrow R) \ \vee \ (Q \nrightarrow R)$$

If $Q \rightarrow R$, then Q is part of the causal structure already described by P. If $Q \nrightarrow R$, then Q has no role in producing the reports that are used to justify it.

In neither case does the concept of qualia provide an independent epistemic foundation.

This result follows directly from the structure of justification. For any entity X to be epistemically accessible through reports R, it must satisfy:

$$X \rightarrow R$$

If this condition fails, then R cannot function as evidence for X. The concept of qualia does not provide a stable way to satisfy this condition while remaining independent of the processes that generate the reports.

The conclusion is that the appeal to qualia as an epistemic ground is structurally unstable. Either qualia are integrated into the explanatory system, or they cannot be justified within it.

7 The Hard Problem as a Derived Conceptual Artifact

The preceding sections have established three constraints. First, the distinction between first-person and third-person descriptions does not by itself justify an ontological distinction. Second, the concept of qualia does not introduce a causal role or a distinguishable difference within the explanatory structure. Third, no stable epistemic link can be established between qualia and the reports used to justify them.

Given these results, the standard formulation of the hard problem can be reconsidered.

The problem is typically stated as follows: even if a complete physical or functional description P of a system is given, it remains unclear why such a system should be accompanied by subjective experience (Chalmers, 1995, 1996). This is often expressed as a demand to explain a relation of the form

$$P \rightarrow E,$$

where E denotes the subjective or qualitative aspect of experience.

The aim of the following reconstruction is not to deny the force of this problem as it appears in the literature, but to identify the step at which its formal structure is introduced.

This formulation presupposes that E has already been established as an independent explanatory element. The previous analysis shows that this presupposition is not justified. The concept of qualia fails to introduce a causal role (Section 4), does not produce a distinguishable difference (Section 5), and does not satisfy conditions of epistemic grounding (Section 6). Under these conditions, E is not independently defined within the explanatory framework.

The structure of the hard problem can therefore be made explicit. Let A_1 denote first-person access and A_3 denote third-person access. It is unproblematic that

$$A_1 \neq A_3,$$

in the sense that the modes of access differ. The standard argument proceeds by introducing an additional term E such that

$$(A_1 \neq A_3) \;\Rightarrow\; \exists E \quad (E \notin P),$$

and then asking:

$$\text{Why } P \to E?$$

The critical step is the introduction of E. As shown in Section 2, no criterion is provided that licenses the transition from a difference in access to the existence of an additional ontological or explanatory element. The implication

$$(A_1 \neq A_3) \;\Rightarrow\; \exists E$$

is not established by the premises, but introduced at the level of interpretation.

Once E is introduced, the problem of relating P and E follows automatically. The appearance of an explanatory gap is therefore a consequence of inserting an additional term into the model, rather than the discovery of a feature of the system itself. This also helps explain why strategies that relocate the gap at the level of concepts remain compatible with the present diagnosis: even if the gap is conceptual rather than ontological, the introduction of an additional explanatory posit still requires independent justification.

This further explains why the hard problem appears resistant to solution. The question

$$\text{Why } P \to E?$$

cannot be answered as long as E lacks independent specification. It asks for an explanation of the relation between a well-defined structure (P) and an undefined or unsupported element (E). The depth of the problem arises from the form of the question, not from an established explanatory requirement.

The correct prior question is therefore not why physical processes give rise to qualia, but whether the introduction of E is warranted at all. If E is removed, the structure reduces to

$$P \to P,$$

that is, the system is explained in terms of its own organization, without introducing an additional posit. No additional explanatory gap remains.

The conclusion is that the hard problem does not identify a fundamental limitation of physical or functional explanation. It is the result of a conceptual transition in which a difference in access is reinterpreted as an ontological distinction. Once this transition is made explicit and removed, the problem no longer retains its original form.

8 Structural Reinterpretation

The preceding analysis shows that the concept of qualia does not satisfy minimal conditions for explanatory use. This does not imply that experience is eliminated or denied. Rather, it indicates that the features attributed to qualia must be understood differently.

The properties commonly associated with qualia, such as subjectivity and immediacy, can be interpreted as features of system organization. In particular, they reflect differences in access and integration within the system. First-person access corresponds to the internal availability of information, while third-person access corresponds to externally observable structure.

Under this interpretation, no additional ontological layer is required. The phenomena that motivate the introduction of qualia can instead be described in terms of how a system organizes, processes, and integrates information. This shift is consistent with approaches that aim to relate first-person and third-person descriptions within a unified framework (Seth, 2018). The distinction remains at the level of description, without requiring a corresponding distinction in what exists.

9 Evaluation by Minimal Criteria

The concept of qualia can now be evaluated against the criteria introduced in Section 3.

First, qualia do not specify a causal role. Either they are causally integrated into the system, in which case they are not independent, or they are causally inert, in which case they cannot contribute to explanation.

Second, qualia do not produce a distinguishable difference. If no observable or functional difference can be specified, the concept does not alter the explanatory structure. If a difference is specified, it becomes part of that structure.

Third, qualia do not define conditions of application or failure. There is no clear criterion for when qualia are present or absent that can be independently evaluated.

Taken together, these results show that the concept does not meet minimal conditions for explanatory inclusion. It does not extend the explanatory framework, but re-describes it.

10 Implications

The analysis has several implications for the interpretation of the problem of consciousness.

First, the explanatory gap does not identify a limitation of physical or functional accounts, but reflects a transition in how experience is conceptualized. The gap arises when a difference in access is treated as a difference in ontology.

Second, the introduction of qualia does not extend explanatory structure, but reorganizes it. It replaces a single framework with a dual structure without specifying what is gained by this move.

Third, resolving the problem does not require eliminating experience, but clarifying the concepts used to describe it. Once the transition from description to ontology is made explicit, the need for an additional explanatory layer disappears. What disappears is not experience, but the need to posit a further explanatory layer in order to account for it.

11 Conclusion

The central results of the paper can be summarized in three points.

- The paper identifies a structural transition in reasoning in which a difference in access (first-person versus third-person) is reinterpreted as a difference in ontology. It argues that this transition is not justified and that it generates the appearance of an explanatory gap.
- The paper introduces minimal diagnostic criteria for explanatory concepts and shows that qualia, understood as non-functional and non-relational properties, do not satisfy these criteria. As a result, qualia do not function as a justified explanatory posit within a theory of consciousness.
- The paper provides a reconstruction of the hard problem as a derived conceptual artifact. Once the additional explanatory term is removed, no explanatory content is lost, and the problem no longer retains its original form.

Taken together, these results support a more general conclusion. The concept of qualia does not identify an independently defined feature that requires explanation. Rather, it reflects a way of organizing descriptions of experience that, when reinterpreted as an ontological distinction, generates the appearance of a further problem.

From this perspective, the hard problem should not be understood as revealing a gap between two independently established domains, but as arising from the introduction of an additional explanatory term that lacks clear criteria of application, causal role, or epistemic grounding. Once this term is removed, the demand to explain its relation to physical or functional processes no longer arises.

The contribution of the paper is not to offer a new ontology of consciousness, but to clarify the conditions under which explanatory distinctions are introduced. It provides a structural criterion for distinguishing between concepts that extend explanation and those that merely redescribe what is already given. In this respect, the contribution of the paper is methodological rather than metaphysical.

The argument does not eliminate experience or deny its subjective character. It rejects only a specific interpretation in which experience is treated as an additional explanatory entity. What

remains is not an absence of phenomena, but a reorientation of the explanatory task: instead of accounting for a separate qualitative layer, the focus shifts to how systems organize, integrate, make available experiential states within a unified explanatory framework.

A Replies to Possible Objections

A.1 Does the argument presuppose physicalism?

The argument does not assume physicalism as a substantive ontological thesis. It analyzes the structure of the problem as it is typically formulated. In particular, the reference to physical or functional description is already present in standard comparisons, such as cases involving physical or functional equivalence. The analysis does not introduce this reference, but makes explicit its role within the argument.

A.2 Are qualia treated as explanans rather than explanandum?

The argument does not depend on treating qualia as explanatory principles. Even if qualia are understood as explanandum, that is, as what requires explanation, they must still satisfy minimal conditions of conceptual determinacy. In order to function as a legitimate target of explanation, a concept must specify conditions of application, allow for epistemic grounding, or enter into explanatory relations. The analysis shows that qualia, understood as non-functional and non-relational properties, fail to meet these conditions.

A.3 Does the argument deny the existence of subjective experience?

The argument does not deny the existence of experience or its subjective character. It accepts that first-person and third-person descriptions differ. The claim is limited to the interpretation of this difference. A distinction in access does not by itself justify a distinction in ontology. The analysis concerns the role of the concept of qualia within explanation, not the existence of experiential states.

A.4 What about the phenomenal concepts strategy?

The phenomenal concepts strategy maintains that the apparent gap between physical and phenomenal descriptions is conceptual rather than ontological. This is broadly consistent with the present analysis. However, the argument developed here goes further. While the phenomenal concepts strategy may explain why there appears to be a gap, the present paper questions whether qualia, understood as non-functional and non-relational properties, constitute a sufficiently determinate explanatory posit at all. The point is not only that the gap may be conceptual, but that the posit introduced to capture it may fail to do any genuine explanatory work.

A.5 What about conceivability and zombie arguments?

Arguments based on conceivability typically aim to show that a difference between physical structure and subjective experience is coherent. The present analysis does not deny this coherence.

Instead, it questions whether such a difference has explanatory significance. If a distinction produces no difference in causal structure, observable behavior, or epistemic access, then it does not function as an explanatory distinction, regardless of its conceivability.

A.6 Can qualia be epiphenomenal?

Epiphenomenal accounts allow qualia to exist without causal influence. The analysis shows that this position faces an epistemic difficulty. If qualia do not contribute to the production of reports about experience, then such reports cannot provide justification for their existence. As a result, the concept lacks a stable epistemic basis within the explanatory framework.

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